GROUND REPORT FROM NEPAL

THE HARD ROAD TO RECOVERY

As the Nepal government counts the costs of the terrible natural disaster, the focus is on the many portents of climate change and the restitution due to one of the world's lowest carbon emitters

By **PRAGYAN THAPA GHIMIRE**



A week after massive flash floods scythed across the Nepal–Tibet border on August 26, 1,292 people have been confirmed dead, with nearly 5,000 reported missing—figures that have steadily crept up since the incident. It is the most fatal and destructive "natural" disaster to have hit Nepal since the 2015 earthquakes.

Much of the worst affected areas, along the floods' 70 km course in Nepal, remain uninhabitable. Bodies swept away have been found as far as 250 km away in neighbouring India. The preliminary cost of rebuilding villages, towns, bridges, roads and other vital infrastructure destroyed by the flood has been estimated at a staggering $4 billion plus—a tenth of Nepal's GDP.

The northern Nepali districts of Rasuwa and Nuwakot have served as vital trading and travel points connecting Nepal and Tibet for centuries, in addition to being pilgrimage sites for Hindus and Buddhists. Some of those travelling to the area when the floods occurred were there for the occasion of Janai Purnima (Raksha Bandhan) on August 27. The region also has the highest concentration of hydroelectricity power plants in Nepal—all 12 of which were left either fully or partially damaged, leading to a loss of 431 MW.

As news of the floods came in, Nepal's government deployed army and police officials for rescue efforts—over 21,000 were deployed in the week since, alongside hundreds of sorties by military and civilian helicopters. Donations to the Prime Minister's Disaster Relief Fund had reached almost 8 billion Nepali rupees by September 1, with foreign nations pledging over $25 million to relief efforts, as also to help with rebuilding infrastructure and in-kind donations. Hundreds of social workers are collecting relief materials as well. An early controversy arose when the government was reported to have declined foreign search and rescue teams—538 foreign nationals were initially reported missing—citing self-sufficiency and negative experiences in coordinating with foreign rescue workers after the 2015 earthquake. This was denied by Prime Minister Balendra Shah in a September 2 address to parliament. He stated that foreign rescue missions have been welcomed since the disaster's onset.

The preliminary cost of rebuilding villages, towns, bridges, roads and other infrastructure destroyed by the flood is estimated at $4 billion-plus—a tenth of Nepal's GDP

Nepal's National Disaster Risk Reduction and Management Authority (NDRRMA) reports that almost 12,000 people have been rescued. Unfortunately, further efforts have been hampered by difficulties in navigating the ravaged terrain and impending risk of more floods—compounded by both newly formed barrier lakes and heavy monsoon rain. The alleged inability of the government to efficiently coordinate with, and allocate resources to, local bodies as well as the seemingly performative and unneeded presence of politicians and celebrities in disaster sites has been met with widespread criticism. Home minister Sudan Gurung has decided to serve as a rescue worker on the ground, raising questions whether he should instead concentrate on the administrative and policy-based facets of relief operations, as his job demands.

The devastation has put the focus on warnings from prescient experts, who for decades